

Violence Against Women

Women are considered an essential and vital part of society, playing a prominent role in its construction and development. A woman may be a mother, a sister, a wife, or a friend, and these are roles we clearly see in our daily lives. Nevertheless, women continue to be visibly subjected, right before society's eyes, to assault and violence that may cause them physical or psychological harm.

Violence against women takes multiple forms; it may manifest as insults, threats, control over a woman's life and behaviors, preventing her from education or work, controlling her economic resources, or forcing her to do things she does not wish to do. Violence against women is a global phenomenon not limited to a specific society, though its degree and causes vary from one society to another. Therefore, confronting this phenomenon requires researching the causes of its emergence and the factors that lead to its entrenchment within society itself.

Among the causes of violence practiced against women is the feeling among some men of weakness or loss of authority in front of women, often accompanied by an intense fear of losing control over her or being unable to impose authority, which may drive some individuals to resort to torture, beatings, and violent acts.

This can also be linked to the way males are raised from childhood, as their thoughts and outlook on life may be confined within a narrow framework of mistaken concepts about how to treat women. They are sometimes raised to believe that the man is the superior party, that his opinions are correct, and that in the event of a disagreement, he has the right to impose his view, while the woman is required to be obedient to his desires and decisions. These ideas are linked to old customs and traditions that need review. Conversely, a woman may be raised from childhood in a way that makes her feel subordinate to men. In this manner, a sense of superiority and control is fostered in the man, while the woman is depicted as weak, which is an unhealthy approach in social and intellectual upbringing.

Without being biased toward women or restricting the causes of this phenomenon solely to the concept of patriarchy, we can present another set of reasons contributing to the spread of this dangerous phenomenon within society, most notably economic circumstances. Poverty and a woman's complete financial dependence on a man often drive her to tolerate violence in order to secure her livelihood. As seen in many cases, numerous mothers endure abuse and violence throughout their lives for the sake of their children. This is often linked to the lack of financial resources and suitable economic conditions, in addition to a woman's lack of awareness regarding her capabilities, strength, and rights.

Another economic cause of violence against women is her lack of economic independence. When a woman does not have an independent source of income, she may need family members—such as her father, brother, or husband—to provide for her basic needs. This economic dependence can

make it difficult for her to make a decision to move away from an abusive environment or get rid of it.

Moreover, we must not overlook the political and institutional aspect of this problem. When a woman enters a field in which men are accustomed to working, some may look at her with a perspective that minimizes her capabilities, intelligence, or competence. In some cases, it may even reach the point where those in positions of power and authority exploit their positions to turn a blind eye to acts of violence committed against women and fail to punish perpetrators, which facilitates the continuation of violence and leads to the absence of accountability and punishment.

There is also a set of personal and individual factors that may contribute to the increase of violence against women, including a woman not possessing a strong personality that enables her to look at a man as an equal human being and a partner, rather than viewing him from a standpoint of fear. Fear of the other party can make a woman constantly hesitate to cooperate, coordinate, and engage in joint work.

Furthermore, some prevailing ideas and views in society can themselves turn into an obstacle and a source of violence against women. Some women are subjected to criticism, mockery, and ridicule because of many things related to their lives, such as the way they dress, their manner of speaking, or even their physical appearance. When a woman lacks a strong personality or the ability to face these social pressures, she may become more vulnerable to various forms of violence within society and may yield many rights she should enjoy. This can also be attributed to weak legal and social awareness on the part of the woman herself.

In this context, a woman tries to prove her presence, defend her rights, and leave her mark in society, which may sometimes lead to her exposure to violence. This is a crucial point, because a woman's silence may be interpreted in society as weakness, but under no circumstances should the victim's silence be interpreted as the cause of the violence she was subjected to. For silence is often the result of fear, economic dependence, pressure, threats, the desire to protect children, or the lack of support and assistance.

It is unfortunate that in previous periods women suffered from a lack of awareness of their rights; however, today, compared to past years, they have become more aware and conscious of their rights and status. Therefore, first and foremost, we must accept the fact that a woman is a human being, and she has the right to enjoy freedom just as a man does. She has the right to work, the right to live her life, and the right to enjoy it. No one has the right to confine her to a corner of her home as if she were a prisoner under the pretexts of protection, customs, traditions, culture, or religion, in whatever way someone deems correct according to their own understanding.

In the end, addressing violence against women is not limited to raising awareness among women alone; rather, it requires changing social attitudes and orientations, strengthening laws and ensuring their effective implementation, punishing perpetrators of violence, providing economic and social support to victims, and creating an environment in which human beings can exercise their rights and freedoms without fear.

